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UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

WEDNESDAY, 21 OCTOBER 2026

13 must-know stories, 23 Prelims facts, 16 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 798 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

Open this brief online: summaries, Ask Intel and practice MCQs

MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court judgment opens up the religion-neutrality of OBC classification for debate

A recent Supreme Court judgment on OBC classification raised questions about religion-neutrality and the nature of backwardness among converts. The Supreme Court clarified that non-Hindu communities can qualify as OBCs while distinguishing how backwardness is evaluated for Hindu versus non-Hindu OBCs, particularly regarding religious converts. The Supreme Court clarifies that non-Hindu communities can be OBC, but distinguishes between the sources of backwardness for Hindu OBCs and non-Hindu OBCs on the question of continuing backwardness for converts

When: 2026-10-21 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court of India · **Prelims:** The Supreme Court clarified that non-Hindu communities can be OBC.; The judgment distinguishes between the sources of backwardness for Hindu and non-Hindu OBCs.

> ***Why it matters —*** *It impacts the inclusion criteria and creamy layer determinations for minority communities seeking OBC status.; It addresses complex questions of social stratification and caste dynamics across different religious groups in India.*

Static — Other Backward Classes (OBC) represent socially and educationally backward classes of citizens identified under the Indian Constitution. Articles 15(4) and 16(4) of the Constitution empower the State to make special provisions for the advancement of any socially and educationally backward classes. The Mandal Commission (Second Backward Classes Commission) recommended 27 percent reservation for OBCs in central government jobs in 1980.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Social Justice & Welfare · Prelims angle: Judgment

The Hindu: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court Constitution Bench Ruling: Judicial Pronouncements Hold Absolute Primacy Over CBEC Circulars

The ruling was delivered by a Supreme Court Constitution Bench to resolve conflicts between judicial interpretations and administrative tax circulars. The Supreme Court Constitution Bench ruled that judicial pronouncements have absolute primacy over administrative circulars issued by the Central Board of Excise and Customs.

When: 2026-10-21 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Supreme Court Constitution Bench, Central Board of Excise and Customs · **Prelims:** The ruling was delivered by a Supreme Court Constitution Bench.; The case involved circulars issued by the Central Board of Excise and Customs.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reinforces the supremacy of judicial interpretation over executive instructions in tax matters.; Provides greater legal certainty and protection for taxpayers against conflicting administrative orders.*

Static — A Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court consists of at least five judges, set up under Article 145(3) of the Constitution to decide substantial questions of law involving the interpretation of the Constitution. The Central Board of Excise and Customs, now known as the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs, is a statutory body under the Central Board of Revenue Act, 1963. Administrative circulars issued by revenue boards provide clarification for tax authorities but cannot override statutory provisions or judicial interpretations laid down by courts.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

TaxCorp AI: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

BNSS Expands Safeguards For Public Servants Before Judicial Order For FIR Registration : Supreme Court...

The Supreme Court made observations regarding the interpretation and scope of statutory protections under the newly enacted criminal code. The Supreme Court highlighted that the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) provides broader safeguards for public servants prior to the issuance of a judicial order for FIR registration.

When: 2026-10-21 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court · **Prelims:** The statute discussed in the context of expanded safeguards is the BNSS.

Why it matters — *It clarifies the legal thresholds and protections available to public servants performing official duties.; It impacts how courts handle complaints against government officials before directing police investigations.*

Static — The Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) replaced the colonial-era Code of Criminal Procedure, 1973, to overhaul India's criminal procedure laws. Statutory safeguards for public servants often require prior sanction or inquiry before prosecution to prevent frivolous litigation and harassment during duty. The Supreme Court of India holds the power of judicial review to interpret statutory provisions and ensure they align with constitutional principles of equality and fairness.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

LiveLaw: read the source

Economy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

PROVISIONAL INDEX OF CORE INDUSTRIES FOR THE MONTH OF SEPTEMBER 2026, AND FINAL INDEX FOR THE MONTH OF AUGUST 2026 WITH BASE YEAR 2022-23

The Index of Core Industries grew by 7.9 per cent provisionally in September 2026 on a year-on-year basis compared to September 2025. The September growth rate was higher than the 5.9 per cent final growth rate recorded in August 2026. Iron Ore, Electricity, Coal, Refinery Products, Cement, and Steel recorded positive year-on-year growth rates in September 2026. Iron Ore registered the highest growth at 18.4 per cent, followed by Electricity at 11.4 per cent and Coal at 10.7 per cent. Refinery Products, Cement, and Steel grew by 10.3 per cent, 9.8 per cent, and 4.9 per cent respectively. Fertilizers, Natural Gas, and Crude Oil witnessed negative growth during September 2026. Coal, Refinery Products, Steel, and Iron Ore served as the major drivers of overall ICI growth in recent months. The cumulative growth rate of ICI during April to September 2026 stood at 5.1 per cent compared to 2.5 per cent previously. The final index for August 2026 was revised upwards to 120.4, taking its year-on-year growth rate from 4.8 to 5.9 per cent.

When: September 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Commerce and Industry · **Prelims:** ICI growth for September 2026 (Provisional) was 7.9 per cent.; Iron Ore recorded the highest sectoral growth rate at 18.4 per cent in September 2026.; Fertilizers, Natural Gas, and Crude Oil witnessed negative growth in September 2026.

Why it matters — *Serves as a reliable high-frequency economic indicator reflecting the health of core infrastructure sectors in India.; Directly influences the calculation and trend analysis of the broader Index of Industrial Production (IIP).*

Static — The Index of Core Industries measures the collective and individual performance of core infrastructure sectors in the Indian economy. There are eight core industries included in the index: Coal, Crude Oil, Natural Gas, Refinery Products, Fertilizers, Steel, Cement, and Electricity. The base year for the Index of Core Industries was revised to 2022-23 to better reflect contemporary economic structures.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Infrastructure & Energy, Agriculture & Allied · Prelims angle: Report/Index, Data/Stats

PIB: read the source · free copy on msn.com · also reported by Business Standard

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Future Rate Hikes to Depend on Growth and Inflation Trends, Says RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra

RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra indicated that interest rate cuts are off the table in the near term. Future monetary policy actions will be limited to either raising rates further or maintaining a pause. The policy stance was shifted to calibrated tightening due to rising and broadening inflationary pressures. The MPC unanimously raised the policy repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50 per cent earlier this month. Data shows 37 per cent of commodities in the CPI basket had inflation above 4 per cent in August. Core inflation increased from 3.9 per cent in July to 4.2 per cent in August. Headline consumer price inflation is projected to reach 6.0 per cent in the third quarter of FY2026-27. India's real GDP growth for FY2026-27 is projected at 7.1 per cent, up from the earlier 6.7 per cent estimate. Some MPC members, including Nagesh Kumar and Ram Singh, favoured retaining a neutral stance instead of calibrated tightening.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** Sanjay Malhotra (RBI Governor), Nagesh Kumar, Ram Singh · **Prelims:** The policy repo rate was raised by 25 basis points to 5.50 per cent.; CPI inflation is projected to reach 6.0 per cent in the third quarter of FY2026-27.; Real GDP growth for FY2026-27 is projected at 7.1 per cent.

Why it matters — *Signals a decisive shift in monetary policy towards curbing stubborn inflationary pressures.; Highlights the central bank's vigilance over broadening price pressures and rising core inflation.*

Static — The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) is a statutory body established under Section 45ZB of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. It is tasked with determining the policy interest rate required to achieve the inflation target while keeping growth in mind. The MPC comprises six members: the RBI Governor (Chairperson, ex-officio), a Deputy Governor, one officer of the RBI, and three external members appointed by the central government.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Data/Stats, Report/Index

aninews.in: read the source · also reported by Mint, Economic Times

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Inflation remains top of mind, MPC minutes show

The Reserve Bank of India raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.5% during its October 5-7 Monetary Policy Committee meeting. The MPC voted by 4:2 to shift its monetary policy stance from neutral to calibrated tightening. A majority of members backed further policy tightening to tame inflation, which is nearing the 6% ceiling of the RBI. Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta stated that a further increase in the policy rate might be needed to keep inflation low and anchor inflationary expectations. Governor Sanjay Malhotra noted that the new stance signals rate cuts are off the table in the near term, leaving only rate hikes or pauses. Executive Director Indranil Bhattacharyya urged the committee to set aside cautiousness and act pre-emptively against inflation. External member Saugata Bhattacharya argued that current and forecast real interest rates remain too low to ensure price stability. External members Ram Singh and Nagesh Kumar backed the rate hike but opposed shifting the stance, citing supply-driven pressures and trade uncertainties.

When: 2026-10-21 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India, Monetary Policy Committee, Poonam Gupta, Sanjay Malhotra · **Prelims:** The repo rate was raised by 25 basis points to 5.5%.; The MPC stance was shifted from neutral to calibrated tightening by a 4:2 vote.; CPI inflation is projected at 6.0% in the October-December quarter.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Signals the potential start of a sustained rate-hike cycle rather than a single off rate correction.; Reflects the central bank's proactive stance to prevent supply-side shocks from becoming generalized inflation.*

Static — The Monetary Policy Committee is a statutory body constituted under Section 45ZB of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934, to determine the policy interest rate required to achieve the inflation target. The MPC comprises six members: the RBI Governor (Chairperson), a Deputy Governor in charge of monetary policy, one officer of the Bank, and three external members appointed by the Central Government. External members hold office for a period of four years and are not eligible for re-appointment.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

Economic Times: read the source · free copy on msn.com · also reported by RBI, IndexBox, BusinessLine, The Hindu, Moneycontrol.com, ThePrint, Mint, Livemint

GS3 MAKE NOTES

FDI Limit In PSU Banks May Rise To 49%, Government Prepares Draft Cabinet Note As RBI Backs Proposal

The Centre is considering increasing the foreign direct investment limit in public sector banks from 20 percent to 49 percent. The Finance Ministry has prepared a draft Cabinet note proposing this higher FDI ceiling and sought comments from other ministries. The Reserve Bank of India has supported the move and recommended raising the investment limit at the earliest. Currently, foreign investment of up to 74 percent is permitted in private sector banks, compared to 20 percent for public sector banks. Among the 12 public sector banks, State Bank of India has the highest foreign investment holding at 11.07 percent. Canara Bank follows with the second-highest foreign investment holding at 10.55 percent. India's overall FDI equity inflows increased by 6 percent to USD 19.81 billion during April-June FY27. Tamil Nadu topped the state-wise investment chart with USD 5.95 billion during this period, followed by Maharashtra and Delhi.

When: 2026-10-21 · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** Finance Ministry, Reserve Bank of India · **Prelims:** Existing FDI limit in public sector banks is 20 percent.; Proposed FDI limit in public sector banks is 49 percent.; FDI limit in private sector banks is 74 percent.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Attracts more foreign capital into India's public sector banking system.; Reduces the gap in investment ceilings between public and private sector banks.*

Static — Foreign Direct Investment in India is regulated under the Foreign Exchange Management Act and policy guidelines formulated by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade. Public sector banks in India are established and governed by specific nationalisation acts and the Banking Regulation Act, 1949. The Reserve Bank of India acts as the central banking institution, regulating the banking sector and providing policy recommendations on financial sector reforms.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy

freepressjournal.in: read the source · also reported by IndianMandarins

Infrastructure & Energy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

UDAN Turns 10: 687 Routes Operational, Rs. 28,840 Crore Plan Targets 100 Airports and 200 Helipads

India's Regional Connectivity Scheme, UDAN, has completed 10 years since its launch on October 21, 2016, operationalising 687 regional routes. The scheme was designed to improve air connectivity to unserved and underserved regions through capped airfares and financial incentives. A modified phase of UDAN has been introduced with a total financial outlay of Rs. 28,840 crore to run from FY 2026-27 to 2035-36. The new phase allocates Rs. 12,159 crore for developing 100 airports, Rs. 3,661 crore for 200 modern helipads, and Rs. 10,043 crore for airline viability support. A dedicated Challenge Mode Portal allows states and UTs to nominate airstrips and helipads for development, backed by 21 signed MoUs. The North-Eastern region remains a key focus with 90 priority routes operationalised and 52 aerodromes identified across states. The modified scheme includes Rs. 400 crore for acquiring two HAL Dhruv helicopters for Pawan Hans and two HAL Dornier aircraft for Alliance Air. As of October 2026, the scheme has facilitated travel for 1.72 crore passengers and disbursed Rs. 5,091.23 crore as Viability Gap Funding.

When: October 21, 2016 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Civil Aviation · **Prelims:** UDAN was launched on October 21, 2016.; The modified UDAN scheme has an outlay of Rs. 28,840 crore for FY 2026-27 to 2035-36.; As of October 2026, 687 regional routes and 95 aerodromes have been operationalised.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Expands affordable air travel to tier-2 and tier-3 cities, boosting regional economic activity and employment.; Improves connectivity in challenging terrains such as the North-East and remote areas like Ladakh and island regions.*

Static — The Regional Connectivity Scheme (RCS) - UDAN (Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik) is a flagship program under the Ministry of Civil Aviation, Government of India. It aims to stimulate regional air connectivity and make air travel affordable for the masses in unserved and underserved regions of the country. The scheme uses Viability Gap Funding (VGF) paid to participating airline operators to subsidize seat caps and make regional operations commercially viable.

Syllabus: GS3: Infrastructure & Energy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

indianmasterminds.com: read the source · also reported by Utkarsh Classes

Environment & Ecology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

As climate summit approaches, UN reports existing 1.5C warming limit is no longer achievable

A UN climate report released Wednesday finds the globe will unavoidably slip past the Paris Agreement's 1.5-degree Celsius warming target in the next few years. The annual UN Emissions Gap report was designed to inform decision-makers headed into the upcoming COP31 global climate talks in Turkey next month. This report marks the first time authors have pronounced that missing the 1.5C target is imminent and unavoidable, declaring the previous window closed. Instead of past gaps, the report examines new emissions overshoot scenarios to limit peak warming to 1.7 to 1.8 degrees C before bringing temperatures back down. The lowest overshoot scenario requires global greenhouse gas emissions to be slashed by 18 percent by 2030, 45 percent by 2035, and 69 percent by 2040 relative to 2025 levels. Meeting this pathway requires tripling renewable electricity capacity by 2035, phasing out coal by 2040, and major scaling up of unproven carbon removal technologies. Fulfillment of existing emissions reduction pledges would only yield a 5 to 8 percent cut by 2030, leading to a peak warming of about 2.6 degrees C.

When: 2026-10-21 · **Where:** Turkey · **Who:** Inger Andersen, Michael Mann, Kate Marvel, UNEP · **Prelims:** The UN Environment Program (UNEP) headquarters is based in Nairobi.; The lowest overshoot scenario requires global greenhouse gas emissions to be slashed by 18 percent by 2030.; Fulfillment of existing emission pledges yields a 5 to 8 percent emissions cut by 2030.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the failure of current global climate policies and pledges to prevent imminent breaching of the 1.5C threshold.; Shifts focus toward managing an emissions overshoot scenario and scaling up unproven carbon removal technologies.*

Static — The Paris Agreement is a legally binding international treaty on climate change adopted at COP21 in Paris in 2015, aiming to limit global warming to well below 2 degrees C, preferably to 1.5 degrees C. The UN Environment Programme (UNEP) is the leading global environmental authority established in 1972, headquartered in Nairobi, Kenya, setting the global environmental agenda. The Emissions Gap report is published annually by UNEP to assess the gap between countries' greenhouse gas emission reduction pledges and what is needed to avert the worst climate impacts.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, International Relations · Prelims angle: Report/Index

cnn.com: read the source · also reported by The Hindu, Hindustan Times, Down To Earth, CNN, The New Indian Express, NDTV

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India to mandate 1% SAF blending for international flights from January

The mandate is coming into effect in two months while the national SAF policy and carbon credit frameworks remain absent. India is set to mandate a 1 percent Sustainable Aviation Fuel blending for international flights starting in January, amid industry concerns over missing policy frameworks. With two months left for international obligations to kick in, aviation industry sources voice concern over the absence of a national SAF policy or a framework for carbon credits

When: January · **Where:** India · **Who:** Aviation industry sources · **Prelims:** SAF blending mandate for international flights: 1 percent.; Timeline for implementation: January.; Key industry concern: Absence of a national SAF policy or carbon credit framework.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Crucial step for India to meet its international aviation emission reduction commitments.; Highlights the operational challenges faced by airlines in the absence of domestic policy support.*

Static — Sustainable Aviation Fuel is a cleaner drop-in substitute for conventional jet fuel derived from renewable biomass and waste resources. The Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation aims to stabilize net carbon emissions from international civil aviation. India is a member of the International Civil Aviation Organization, which oversees global standards and targets for aviation decarbonization.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Governance & Policy

The Hindu: read the source

Science & Technology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Aditya-L1 mission offers new insights into the direction of solar eruptions

Scientists at the Indian Institute of Astrophysics used data from Aditya-L1's VELC payload to generate new Doppler velocity images of the solar corona. These images provide missing information on how coronal mass ejections travel along the Sun-Earth direction during solar eruptions. Coronal mass ejections are massive clouds of hot plasma thrown out by the Sun that can disrupt near-Earth space if directed toward us. Researchers applied the Doppler effect concept to light waves, where positive velocities show plasma moving away and negative ones show it moving towards the observer. The Visible Emission Line Coronagraph is currently the only instrument able to generate such images due to its unique spectroscopic observing capability in the visible wavelength range. The VELC payload operations team at the Indian Institute of Astrophysics developed the software to process this data. The processing details were successfully published in the Astrophysical Journal following international peer review. These processed velocity images will now be shared with the broader scientific community for further research.

When: 2026-10-21 · **Where:** Sun-Earth L1 point · **Who:** Indian Institute of Astrophysics and ISRO · **Prelims:** VELC stands for Visible Emission Line Coronagraph.; Aditya-L1 is India's maiden solar mission and second astronomy observatory after AstroSat.; The Lagrange point L1 is located about 1.5 million km from Earth.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides crucial early measurement of whether solar eruptions and coronal mass ejections are headed directly towards Earth.; Enhances India's scientific capability in space weather forecasting to protect near-Earth space infrastructure.*

Static — Aditya-L1 is the Indian Space Research Organisation's first space-based observatory-class solar mission and its second astronomy observatory after AstroSat. The spacecraft is placed in a halo orbit around the first Lagrange point of the Sun-Earth system, approximately 1.5 million kilometres away from Earth. Lagrange points are positions in space where the gravitational forces of two large bodies, like the Sun and Earth, produce enhanced regions of attraction and repulsion.

Syllabus: GS3: Science & Technology, Infrastructure & Energy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme

civilsdaily.com: read the source · also reported by Insights on India

Defence

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Army Commanders' Conference begins, Rajnath Singh to release Land Warfare Doctrine

The three-day Army Commanders' Conference began in New Delhi on Wednesday, running from October 21-23. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh is scheduled to release the 'Land Warfare Doctrine' during the conference. The doctrine provides an overarching framework to prepare the Indian Army for the evolving character of warfare and future conflicts. The apex-level biannual forum is chaired by the Chief of the Army Staff, Gen Dhiraj Seth. Senior leadership will deliberate on the evolving security environment, operational preparedness, and capability development. Chief of Defence Staff Gen N S Raja Subramani and other top officials will deliver talks on contemporary security issues. The Defence Minister will unveil the annual United Nations Journal and felicitate Indian Army personnel for UN peacekeeping service. The Chief of the Army Staff will confer awards for Green Military Stations and Aviation Flight Safety to recognise excellence.

When: October 21-23, 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Rajnath Singh, Gen Dhiraj Seth, Gen N S Raja Subramani · **Prelims:** The conference is held from October 21-23.; The Chief of the Army Staff is Gen Dhiraj Seth.; The Land Warfare Doctrine is being released by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides a strategic platform to review ongoing transformation initiatives and formulate future policy directions for the Indian Army.; Releases the Land Warfare Doctrine to prepare the military for modern and future conflicts.*

Static — The Army Commanders' Conference is an apex-level biannual event that formulates important policy decisions and strategic directions for the Indian Army. The Chief of the Army Staff (COAS) heads the Indian Army and commands the force from the Army Headquarters in New Delhi. India has historically been one of the largest troop contributors to United Nations peacekeeping missions globally.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence

Hindustan Times: read the source · also reported by The Hindu

GS3 MAKE NOTES

BrahMos-II Eyes 2027–2028 Test as India Weighs Hypersonic Strike Power

Recent defense sector reports highlighted the upcoming testing timeline for the BrahMos-II hypersonic missile project. India is scheduling the first tests for the BrahMos-II hypersonic missile between 2027 and 2028 to boost its strike capabilities.

When: 2027–2028 · **Where:** India · **Who:** DRDO and NPO Mashinostroyeniya · **Prelims:** Target test window for BrahMos-II: 2027 to 2028.; Technology focus: Hypersonic strike power exceeding Mach 5.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Significantly enhances India's deterrence posture and strategic offensive capabilities.; Demonstrates technological advancement in scramjet propulsion and high-speed aerodynamics.*

Static — BrahMos is a joint venture between India's Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and Russia's NPO Mashinostroyeniya. The name BrahMos is a portmanteau formed from the names of two rivers: the Brahmaputra in India and the Moskva in Russia. Hypersonic missiles travel at speeds of Mach 5 or higher and utilize scramjet engine technology for atmospheric flight.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence

Defence Security Asia: read the source

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

DEFENCE EXERCISE QUICK READ

33rd EDITION OF SINGAPORE-INDIA MARITIME BILATERAL EXERCISE (SIMBEX-2026) COMMENCES AT VISAKHAPATNAM

The Indian Navy and the Republic of Singapore Navy began the 33rd edition of SIMBEX-2026 in Visakhapatnam to enhance operational interoperability. The exercise is held from October 21 to 26, 2026, featuring professional engagements and maritime-warfare drills. The core objective is to strengthen maritime cooperation, address common security challenges, and promote peace in the Indo-Pacific.

PIB: source

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED QUICK READ

India hosts Agrivoltaics World Conference 2026 for the first time in the Global South

India is hosting the 7th AgriVoltaics World Conference from October 21 to October 23 under the theme Powering the Global South. The conference was jointly inaugurated by Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and New and Renewable Energy Minister Pralhad Joshi. Prime Minister Narendra Modi shared an article highlighting how agrivoltaics combines solar power generation with agricultural activity to boost incomes.

PIB: source

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED SCHEME QUICK READ

Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare to Launch ‘Khet Bachao Abhiyan – Rabi 2026’ tomorrow; Campaign to Continue Till 30 November

The Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare is launching the nationwide campaign named Khet Bachao Abhiyan-Rabi 2026. The campaign is scheduled to run from 22 October to 30 November 2026. Union Minister Shri Shivraj Singh Chouhan will officially launch the initiative from Karnal in Haryana. The initiative aims to promote sustainable agriculture, improve soil health, and encourage judicious use of agricultural resources.

PIB: source

ECONOMY REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

Largest Economies in the World 2026, IMF Rankings by Nominal GDP & PPP

The International Monetary Fund published its October 2026 World Economic Outlook projections ranking global economies by nominal GDP and Purchasing Power Parity. The projections are triggered by updated economic data tracking global growth, inflation, employment, and currency movements across countries. The core debate centers on the reliability of nominal GDP versus PPP in capturing true economic strength, living standards, and purchasing power.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AGREEMENT/MOU REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

Turkey, Qatar, Pakistan, Indonesia sign defence cooperation accord

Turkey, Qatar, Pakistan and Indonesia signed a memorandum of understanding in Doha to establish a multilateral defence cooperation framework. The agreement aims to strengthen national defence capabilities through joint production, technology transfer, training, and research and development. The accord covers joint R&D projects, co-production of selected components, technical training, engineering expertise sharing, and international marketing adaptation.

Economic Times: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | QUICK READ

Two New Subterranean Fish Species Discovered in Assam

Two previously unknown subterranean fish species have been discovered in wells located in Assam's Goalpara district. The discovery was announced by state environment and forests minister Jayanta Malla Baruah. The newly identified species are Gitchak nakana, a tiny blind loach, and Rakthamichthys anchi, an eel-like fish. Gitchak nakana measures about two centimetres and appears reddish because its transparent body reveals its internal organs and blood.

tribuneindia.com: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | ACT/BILL/RULES | PLACE IN NEWS | QUICK READ

Nanjarayan Bird Sanctuary

It was observed that even after more than four years of notification, Nanjarayan Bird Sanctuary is yet to get through transformation befitting Ramsar Site. The sanctuary is a large shallow wetland located along the north-eastern region of Uthukuli Taluk of Tiruppur District in Tamil Nadu. It is centered on a freshwater lake, which was repaired and restored by King Nanjarayan who ruled the region many centuries ago.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

HISTORY, ART & CULTURE | QUICK READ

Sirpur Cultural and Archaeological Landscape in Chhattisgarh

India added three new locations to the UNESCO World Heritage Convention’s tentative list, announced by the Permanent Delegation of India to UNESCO in Paris. The newly listed sites are the Karst-mud-volcano Complex of Baratang, the Andaman Subduction Volcanoes, and the Sirpur Cultural and Archaeological Landscape. Inclusion on the tentative list is a mandatory procedural step before any location can be considered for formal World Heritage nomination.

ForumIAS: source

DEFENCE | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

Defence Ministry signs Rs. 770 crore BEL deal for low-level surveillance radars for Army

The Ministry of Defence signed a contract worth Rs. 770 crore with Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL) on October 21. The deal is for procuring Improved Low Level Light Weight Radars (LLLR-I) for the Indian Army. The procurement aims to strengthen the Army's capability to detect and track fighter-sized aircraft and small unmanned aerial systems.

Economic Times: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

CAQM invokes Stage-I of GRAP in Delhi-NCR with immediate effect amid sharp rise in AQI

The Commission for Air Quality Management invoked Stage-I of the Graded Response Action Plan across Delhi-NCR with immediate effect. The core issue is deteriorating winter air quality, prompting the Sub-Committee on GRAP to enforce preventive measures. The Central Pollution Control Board bulletin recorded the AQI entering the 'Poor' category, which ranges between 201 and 300.

PIB: source

ECONOMY | QUICK READ

NITI Aayog Framework Sets Data Centre Approval Conditions

NITI Aayog issued a framework outlining regulatory and approval guidelines for data centres. NITI Aayog has introduced a framework laying down specific approval conditions for setting up data centres in India.

Construction World India: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION | QUICK READ

Law Commission of India to organise National Conference on ‘Co-operative Federalism and Law Reforms: National and State Perspectives’

The 23rd Law Commission of India is hosting a National Conference on Co-operative Federalism and Law Reforms at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi. The conference aims to address contemporary issues relating to law reforms, co-operative federalism, and constitutional governance. It seeks to strengthen coordination among States and institutions engaged in law reform while respecting State autonomy.

PIB: source

ECONOMY | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

India launches state-level outreach to help MSMEs, farmers tap FTA export opportunities

The central government is organizing dedicated outreach initiatives with state governments to help farmers, workers, women, youth, MSMEs, and small businesses utilize India's free trade agreements. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal stated that the campaign aims to translate international trade partnerships into meaningful economic opportunities across the country.

BusinessLine: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION | ACT/BILL/RULES | QUICK READ

Ladakh administration dissolves hill council in Kargil, announces panchayat elections on November 21

The State Election Commission of Ladakh has announced that panchayat elections for all panchayat halqas in the Union Territory will be held on November 21. The entire election process is scheduled to be completed by November 30. Ladakh is witnessing panchayat elections after eight years, with the last polls having been conducted in November 2018.

The Hindu: source

ECONOMY | QUICK READ

IMF advises India to let rupee move as first defence amid oil shock

The International Monetary Fund advised India to let the dollar-rupee exchange rate move as the first line of defence amid an ongoing oil shock. Krishna Srinivasan, director of the Asia and Pacific Department at the IMF, stated that exchange rates must act as shock absorbers. The Reserve Bank of India has heavily intervened in the forex market through dollar sales, special windows for oil companies, and reserve requirements.

BusinessLine: source

HEALTH | REPORT/INDEX | QUICK READ

India Ranks Third Globally in Ipsos Quality of Care Perception Index 2026

India ranked third in the Ipsos Quality of Care Perception Index as of October 2026, positioned behind Malaysia and Singapore. The ranking is based on the Ipsos Health Service Report 2026, which recorded that 68% of Indians positively rate their available healthcare quality. The index measures public perceptions and subjective views rather than clinical assessments of treatment quality or health outcomes.

gktoday.in: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | QUICK READ

IUCN assessments place Campanula bergomensis Near Threatened and two Kyzylkum desert plants Endangered

Recent updates to the IUCN Red List status of these specific plants brought them into focus. Recent IUCN assessments have placed the plant species Campanula bergomensis in the Near Threatened category and two Kyzylkum desert plants in the Endangered category.

Bioengineer.org: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | PLACE IN NEWS | QUICK READ

680 mangroves lost for good as Thane road near Ramsar site gets go-ahead

The project received the official go-ahead, triggering environmental concerns over the loss of protected mangroves. A road project near a Ramsar site in Thane has received approval, resulting in the permanent destruction of 680 mangroves.

The Indian Express: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | SCHEME | QUICK READ

PM-DAKSH scheme: Centre introduces Aadhaar authentication rules for beneficiary enrolment and alternative identity verification

The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment issued a Gazette notification on October 16, 2026, introducing Aadhaar authentication rules under the PM-DAKSH scheme. The new framework establishes defined procedures for identity verification and enrolment of applicants and beneficiaries using Aadhaar authentication. The notification addresses failed Aadhaar verifications by providing alternative procedures and identification documents in accordance with prescribed guidelines.

msn.com: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | PLACE IN NEWS | QUICK READ

Arborists To Treat Damaged Trees In Udanti Sitanadi Tiger Reserve Of Chhattisgarh

The Chhattisgarh Forest Department is seeking expert help to save over 500 trees allegedly damaged by encroachers in Karka village of the Udanti Sitanadi Tiger Reserve. The trees were targeted through girdling, where portions of bark are removed to disrupt nutrient supplies and eventually kill the tree. A department inspection between September 22 and October 10 identified around 2,500 girdled trees, mainly consisting of Sal, Bija, and Tendu species.

freepressjournal.in: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | SCHEME | QUICK READ

2 Years of PM Internship Scheme: Progress and Impact

The scheme is in the news as it marks its two-year milestone of progress and impact assessment. The PM Internship Scheme marks two years of implementation focused on providing corporate exposure and skill development to Indian youth.

NEXT IAS: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

India – Finland Joint Statement on the State Visit of President of the Republic of Finland (March 04 - 07, 2026)

The official state visit of the President of Finland to India took place between March 04 and 07, 2026. The President of the Republic of Finland visited India from March 04 to 07, 2026, resulting in a comprehensive joint statement.

Ministry of External Affairs: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

Pakistan, Maldives sign 20 MoUs, target $200m in trade in two years

Pakistan and the Maldives signed 20 memoranda of understanding to boost cooperation in defence, maritime security, and artificial intelligence. The agreements took place during Maldivian President Mohamed Muizzu's three-day visit to Islamabad starting Tuesday upon PM Shehbaz Sharif's invitation. The visit marks the first by a Maldivian president in 11 years and coincides with the 60th anniversary of diplomatic ties established in 1966.

news18.com: source

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS1 GS2 Courts, tribal customs and women's rights

A recent verdict on tribal land succession brought the debate regarding women's rights and customary laws back into the spotlight. An editorial discussing a tribal land succession verdict that tests the complex balance between protecting cultural autonomy and upholding gender equality. A tribal land succession verdict tests the balance between cultural autonomy and gender equality

The Hindu

GS2 The ECI's unfinished lessons

The Election Commission of India's Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls has triggered mass deletions, suspect requests, and debates over polling records. An accurate electoral roll must remove dead, shifted, or duplicate entries while actively keeping every eligible voter to prevent lost votes. Historical precedent from India's first CEC Sukumar Sen shows that correcting wrongful exclusions is as critical as removing erroneous entries.

The Hindu

GS3 India's Corrosion Bill is a material choice problem, not just a maintenance problem

Corrosion costs India roughly Rs. 14.15 lakh crore annually, amounting to about 4.3% of the nation's GDP. Infrastructure alone accounts for Rs. 1.42 lakh crore of these corrosion losses, with nearly Rs. 49,580 crore being easily avoidable. A CII-Nomura Research Institute analysis highlights the massive economic drain caused by premature infrastructure deterioration. Upfront material choices, such as using standard TMT bars instead of galvanised reinforcement, dictate long-term durability and repair needs. Repairing corroded assets creates hidden societal costs including traffic jams, cancelled trains, logistical hurdles, and factory downtime.

Hindustan Times

GS3 Disinvestment is back on the Modi govt's agenda. PSU spending needs scrutiny too

The Union Cabinet recently approved selling over 30 percent of government equity in IDBI Bank, yielding over 26,500 crore in disinvestment receipts for the current year. This move surpasses the annual target of 80,000 crore from asset sales during 2026-27 and revives privatisation after a notable pause. The author notes this is not isolated, as the finance ministry plans to list three more PSUs: IIFCL, Mahanadi Coalfields, and South Eastern Coalfields.

ThePrint

GS2 The Kingdom of Saudi Arabia in dire straits

Saudi Arabia faces a severe security test as Iran blockades the Strait of Hormuz and al-Houthis renew fighting near the Bab al-Mandeb Strait. The crisis was triggered by the breakdown of the 2022 Yemen ceasefire in July, leading to al-Houthi occupation of Red Sea plains. The core issue is the extreme vulnerability of Saudi oil exports and critical maritime routes to combined attacks from state and militia actors.

The Hindu

GS3 Best of Opinion: IDBI sale revives hopes for stalled disinvestment drive

The discussion is prompted by recent commentary on the IDBI sale reviving hopes for the stalled disinvestment drive. Editorials and columns examine Sebi's closing auction framework, higher education vacancies, PSU disinvestment via IDBI sale, insolvency delays, and Delhi's history. Today's editorials and columns examine Sebi's revised closing auction framework, leadership vacancies in higher education, PSU disinvestment, insolvency delays and a book exploring Delhi's history.

Business Standard

GS2 Opinion: Opinion | Why The Saudi-Pak-Turkey Defence Pact May Actually Be An 'Intel' Network

The Mecca Agreement, a security pact between Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Pakistan, was signed on August 7, 2026, with language suggesting a NATO-like alliance. The agreement emerged as a symptom of a collapsing US security order and follows the China-facilitated diplomatic normalisation between Saudi Arabia and Iran in 2023. The full text remains secret, and while the Turkish parliament is yet to ratify it, former Pakistan Army Lieutenant General Nauman Mahmood has been chosen as its first Secretary General.

NDTV

GS3 Harvesting the Sun, and powering the farm

Agrivoltaics combines crop cultivation and solar energy generation on the same land using specialized structures and spacing. Unpredictable weather, input costs, and market prices create financial uncertainty for farming households that public policy must address. The core argument is that agrivoltaics provides cultivators with an additional revenue stream from electricity and lowers power or diesel costs. The favourable microclimate under agri-photovoltaics offers protection against heat stress, drought, excessive solar radiation, and hail.

msn.com

GS2 GS3 US sanctions have India cornered. BRICS charts an escape route

US wars in Ukraine and Iran have placed the dollar and its associated sanctioning power at the center of world affairs. US Treasury sanctions and secondary sanctions penalize non-US companies like Indian and Chinese refineries for dealing with targeted nations. India imports nearly 90% of its crude and has faced severe constraints on its strategic autonomy due to changing US tariffs, waivers, and pressure.

Economic Times

GS3 Tax matters, as does capital: Is it time for India to reconsider its LTCG tax policy on listed equities amid rising global competition?

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman welcomed the ongoing healthy debate regarding long-term capital gains tax and securities transaction tax. Foreign portfolio investors have pulled out about Rs 3.08 lakh crore from Indian equities this year up to October 12. Government data shows tax attributable to equity LTCG rose to Rs 1,29,158 crore for AY2025-26 from Rs 72,249 crore the previous year. Increasing securities transaction tax to compensate for LTCG abolition is unattractive because STT applies regardless of profit or loss.

Economic Times

GS3 Rahul Jacob: The global economy is facing a 'resilience' paradox

The article was published as an opinion piece in Mint on October 21, 2026, analyzing current global economic paradoxes. The global economy is experiencing a resilience paradox where positive macroeconomic data masks deep-seated structural issues like high public debt, rising yields, and AI-driven job fears. Economic data has been strong but the dire views point to big challenges facing governments worldwide.

Mint

GS2 The next stage of India's foreign policy is strategic leverage

India has long cherished strategic autonomy to preserve its independence of judgement and pursue national interests without bloc subordination. The world has changed, and India must now translate its strategic autonomy into strategic power and leverage in a polarized global order. The defining question is whether New Delhi can influence the emerging international order amidst pressures from major powers like the US and China. Interdependence has become the new battleground, with trade, technology, tariffs, sanctions, and energy supplies increasingly weaponized against independence.

ThePrint

GS2 Russia's failed Great Game is back in Afghanistan

Russian officials made simultaneous visits to Afghanistan, Pakistan, and India in mid-October, signalling a renewed strategic push along the South Asian frontier. Russian foreign intelligence chief Sergey Naryshkin visited Kabul on 14 October to meet Taliban intelligence chief Abdul Haq Wasiq. Simultaneously, New Delhi hosted the seventh round of the India-Russia Special Mechanism on Pakistan and Afghanistan. Russian interior minister Vladimir Kolokoltsev visited Pakistan and signed an MoU to strengthen cooperation in combating organised crime.

ThePrint

GS2 GS3 Bitter and sweet: on FSSAI draft restrictions, added sugars in infant foods

The piece is in the news due to the FSSAI releasing draft regulations aimed at restricting added sugars in infant food products. The editorial examines the FSSAI's draft restrictions on added sugars in infant foods, arguing that regulations must be expanded to cover all added sugars comprehensively. The FSSAI must expand restrictions to cover all added sugars in infant foods

The Hindu

GS2 Not just warmth, Rubio's Mumbai visit must give India clarity on US energy policy

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio arrived in Mumbai on 20 October and met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar amid domestic US debates over President Donald Trump's Russia policy. Trump announced on 9 October that Russia would supply over 3,00,000 metric tonnes of diesel to global and American markets by temporarily easing restrictions on Russian fuel. The core issue is whether presidential waiver authority undermines legislative intent, creating tension between immediate economic relief for US voters and long-term strategic pressure on Moscow.

ThePrint

GS3 Look beyond ease of doing business. Economic freedom is India's real path to Viksit Bharat

India aims to become a $30 trillion economy with an $18,000 per capita income by 2047, requiring nearly 10 percent nominal growth annually for 21 years. While India hit 10 percent nominal growth in Q1 of 2026, sustaining this for over two decades is a major challenge. Economic freedom is a core driver of prosperity, but India ranks poorly, placing 88th out of 165 countries in the 2026 Economic Freedom of the World report.

ThePrint

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Internet Access as Fundamental Right – Significance & Challenges The Supreme Court recognised internet access as a fundamental right under Article 21 read with Article 19(1)(a). The ruling emphasizes that children enjoy this right irrespective of age and rejects blanket restrictions on their online access. The court cautioned that age-based bans could risk sensitive data collection, surveillance, and push youth to unsafe platforms.
ForumIAS

Mecca defence pact full text finally out: What role it gives Pakistan The official release of the pact's full text brought its details into the public domain and news spotlight. The full text of the Mecca defence pact has been made public, detailing the specific security arrangements and the military role assigned to Pakistan.
Indian Express

What are the deal contours of India-New Zealand FTA? The Free Trade Agreement between India and New Zealand has come into force, bringing its contours into focus. This explainer outlines the deal contours of the Free Trade Agreement between India and New Zealand, detailing its trade, investment, and student mobility benefits while protecting sensitive sectors.
The Hindu

Rajnath Singh addresses SCO meeting in Dushanbe | What is the SCO? Defence Minister Rajnath Singh represented India at the 25th Meeting of the SCO Council of Heads of Government in Dushanbe. The meeting reviewed progress in multilateral economic and trade cooperation and discussed connectivity measures across transport and digital economy. Rajnath Singh emphasised strengthening practical cooperation in areas like trade, investment, connectivity, innovation, and people-to-people exchanges.
onmanorama.com

What Saudi Arabia's execution of Bangladesh nationals tells us about Islamic law The recent execution of Bangladesh nationals in Saudi Arabia has put the spotlight on Islamic legal procedures. An explainer on the execution of Bangladesh nationals in Saudi Arabia and the principles of Islamic law governing capital punishment.
Indian Express

Knowledge Nugget | What is the difference between Executive Magistrate and Judicial Magistrate The topic is featured as a knowledge nugget for UPSC aspirants to understand the constitutional separation of powers. This explainer details the structural and functional differences between Executive Magistrates and Judicial Magistrates in India's criminal justice system.
Indian Express

ExplainSpeaking | The economic mess at the heart of France's protests The piece provides economic context as protests erupt over France's fiscal policies and economic management. This explainer analyzes the root economic causes, fiscal imbalances, and structural policy failures underlying the widespread protests in France.
Indian Express

Are we in danger of outsourcing all of childhood's learning curves to AI? Growing integration of artificial intelligence into the daily lives and learning environments of children. An analysis of the risks associated with children using artificial intelligence to obtain instant answers instead of developing independent problem-solving skills.
The Hindu

What kept cancer medication unaffordable for so long? The government took action to cap cancer drug trade margins just 18 days after an intervention by the Supreme Court. The government capped trade margins on 137 cancer drugs following a Supreme Court intervention, raising questions about the delay since initial pricing moves in 2019.
Frontline

Medical College To High Court Bench: A Series Of Firsts Is Reshaping Ladakh Ladakh is witnessing a series of institutional changes in healthcare, justice and grassroots governance nearly seven years after becoming a Union Territory. The Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare approved the operationalisation of Ladakh's first government medical college in Leh starting from the 2027-28 academic year.
news18.com

Fake Welfare Schemes, Job Offers, Deepfakes: Why AI Scams Are Getting Harder To Spot The growing sophistication and prevalence of AI-driven scams have put them in the spotlight as a major emerging threat. An explainer detailing how generative artificial intelligence and synthetic media are being exploited by fraudsters to run convincing scams through fake welfare schemes, job offers, and deepfakes.
News18

From France To Germany, Why Europe's Political Centre Is Under Pressure As Far Right Gains Ground The demonstrations were triggered by student outrage over underfunded school infrastructure and staffing shortages before snowballing into widespread fury over fuel prices. At stake is the survival of Europe's centrist political establishment as citizens face declining purchasing power and express deep dissatisfaction with democratic governance.
news18.com

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), Full Form, History, Functions (History, Art & Culture) Vajiram & Ravi
- Outer space should remain realm for cooperation, not conflict: MP Sudha Murty tells UNGA (International Relations) Hindustan Times
- E-Waste Management in India, Rules, Challenges and Solutions (Environment & Ecology) Vajiram & Ravi
- CAQM holds meeting with Delhi Government agencies to review Dust Pollution issues and strengthen Air Pollution Mitigation (Environment & Ecology) PIB
- International Day of the Snow Leopard 2026, Key Facts & Conservation (Environment & Ecology) Vajiram & Ravi
- Rajiv Gandhi National Park, Location, Flora and Fauna, Challenges (Environment & Ecology) Vajiram & Ravi
- India's malaria elimination efforts face the Laheri challenge (Health) Frontline
- Andhra Pradesh SEC halts election process for 100 ULBs after Supreme Court order (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- Solar rooftop installations in West Bengal rise by nearly 7 times via central scheme (Infrastructure & Energy) Hindustan Times
- The sunset test: Why India needs more coal-based power (Infrastructure & Energy) ForumIAS
- India must make growth employment-intensive, not just fast: Ex-RBI chief (Economy) Business Standard
- CCOs SUVIKALP Initiative Advances Sustainable Mine Repurposing, Receives SKOCH Gold Award 2026 (Environment & Ecology) PIB
- India presents a compelling investment proposition for German firms, FICCI says (Economy) Economic Times
- Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Shri Piyush Goyal to Visit Germany and the Netherlands to Strengthen Trade, Investment and Industrial Cooperation (International Relations) PIB
- IMF urges currency flexibility as RBI steps up rupee defence amid oil price pressures, foreign outflows (Economy) Mint
- Anticipation over upcoming EU FTA more than doubles Ferrari orders in India (Economy) The Hindu
- Ayad River (Ahar River), Origin, Course, Tributaries, Significance (Geography) Vajiram & Ravi
- Expanding the Diplomatic Toolbox: Southeast Asia at the New Delhi BRICS Summit (International Relations) fulcrum.sg
- INDIAN AIR FORCE ENGAGES INDUSTRY OUTREACH PROGRAMME ON UNMANNED AND AUTONOMOUS SYSTEMS ROADMAP ON 21 OCT 26 (Defence) PIB
- Seahorse Species (Environment & Ecology) ForumIAS
- Punjab released Rs 2,507.98 crore under Old Age Pension scheme, 24.07 lakh senior citizens benefit (Social Justice & Welfare) Babushahi.com
- Pakistan joins new four-nation defence pact. What is the 'Badr' agreement? Should India be concerned? (International Relations) The Week
- With leaders' summit, 'Quad' hopes to breathe fresh life into grouping (International Relations) The Japan Times
- India, Thailand Discuss Deepening Bilateral Defence Ties Through Joint Air Force Exercises (International Relations) Defence.in
- Bangkok IMF-World Bank meetings: New reports put India's debt, climate, accountability crisis in focus (Economy) Counterview
- PARAKH proposes classroom interventions to address learning gaps found in 2024 survey (Education) Hindustan Times
- Rate cuts off table as RBI MPC flags inflation risks, two dissent on stance (Economy) Business Standard
- World falling 'dangerously short' on climate action, warns UN (Environment & Ecology) The Economic Times
- December MPC meet: A 50 bps repo hike vs 25 bps hike with a wider LAF corridor? SBI Research on two RBI options (Economy) Business Today
- India to Convene 130+ Countries at Bharat RE Summit & Expo 2026 to Advance Global Clean Energy Investment and Partnerships (Environment & Ecology) Press Release Hub
- Sri Lanka reaffirms commitment to regional security cooperation at inaugural BIMSTEC Home Ministers' meeting in New Delhi (International Relations) The Tribune
- DRI seizes more than 9 kg methamphetamine in intensified crackdown on synthetic drug trafficking in Bhopal; One held (Internal Security) PIB
- India's Nuclear Programme: Status, Challenges and Goals (Science & Technology) NEXT IAS
- Disaster Resilience of Telecom Infrastructure in India (Disaster Management) NEXT IAS
- "The commodification of human beings reflects the erosion of intrinsic human worth in favour of instrumental considerations." Elucidate its ethical implications. (Ethics & Integrity) Insights on India
- Delhi high court cites national security, junks CIC order to IAF on PMs' foreign trips (Polity & Constitution) Times of India
- OpenAI to train India's civil servants in AI through Karmayogi Bharat tie-up (Governance & Policy) The Economic Times
- Supreme Court Quashes Allotment of Water Bodies to Private Industrialists — Upholds Environmental Protection. The court ruled that the allotment of water bodies to private entities was illegal, violating environmental protection principles and the rights of local (Polity & Constitution) Lawtext
- India, US 'perfectly aligned' on key issues: Marco Rubio; defends ties with Pakistan (International Relations) Times of India
- New status: Editorial on SC ruling on caste-based quotas after religious conversion (Polity & Constitution) Telegraph India
- India's Updated 2026 Nationally Determined Contribution (2031–2035): Charting the Next Phase of Climate Action (Environment & Ecology) IMPRI Impact and Policy Research Institute
- Third Chair: Who Should Pick India's Election Commissioners (Polity & Constitution) Live Law
- "Economic Cooperation Needs Security": Defence Minister Rajnath Singh Flags Terrorism Threat At SCO (International Relations) Business Today
- Russia's S-500 Offer To India: Technology Transfer, Five S-400s And A Major Strategic Dilemma (Defence) The Times of India
- Right To Electricity Protected U/Art 21, Connection Can't Be Denied Merely Due To Property Ownership... (Polity & Constitution) LiveLaw

- Courts' Hands Aren't Tied To Interfere When Free & Fair Elections Are Polluted By Unconstitutional Or... (Polity & Constitution) LiveLaw
- Pulsing signals reveal hidden structure around a famous neutron star (Science & Technology) PIB
- Govt plans major agrivoltaics programme under next phase of PM-KUSUM: Pralhad Joshi (Agriculture & Allied) ANI News
- Marco Rubio India visit LIVE updates: Rubio to visit Jamnagar refinery today, trip to focus on global energy security (International Relations) Hindustan Times

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 13 must-know, 23 Prelims facts, 49 in the news, 16 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — Economy (8), Environment & Ecology (8), Polity & Constitution (5), Defence (4), International Relations (3), Agriculture & Allied (2), Governance & Policy (2), Science & Technology (1), Infrastructure & Energy (1), History, Art & Culture (1), Health (1). **Nothing today in —** Social Justice & Welfare, Education, Internal Security, Disaster Management, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 3 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 1 · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: nothing today · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 4

Full text — 42 of 64 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 9, PIB 6, Economic Times 5, ThePrint 5, Indian Express 4, news18.com 3, Hindustan Times 2, freepressjournal.in 2, Vajiram & Ravi 2, ForumIAS 2, BusinessLine 2, msn.com 2, civilsdaily.com 1, aninews.in 1

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